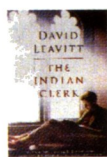


A BEAUTIFUL MIND

A romanticised account of Ramanujan's relationship with an intriguing Cambridge mathematician



THE INDIAN CLERK

by DAVID LEAVITT

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■ By Geeta Doctor

In the case of Srinivasa Ramanujan, the Indian clerk of the title, I have to admit a bias. I live almost next door to the house at Chetpet in Chennai, where the mathematical genius died in 1920. The house still stands in the midst of ancient trees, a mute testimony to his lonely and untimely death.

There is a mystery about the man.

Ramanujan rose from an almost paralysing background of poverty and deprivation, climbing on a string of mathematical formulae he seemed to conjure out of nowhere to hook the attention of G.H. Hardy, a Cambridge don, who had already established himself as a theoretical mathematician. The Ramanujan-Hardy collaboration has been the subject of much debate, with Hardy playing the role of principled mentor in some; in others it's a more Faustian bargain of cold and calculating self-interest that withheld all human sympathy towards Ramanujan as he slowly wasted away during the years (1913-1918) he spent in the England of the Great War. As David Leavitt acknowledges at the end of the book, the lives of both men have been splendidly explored in Robert Kanigel's *The Man Who Knew Infinity: A Life of the Genius Ramanujan*.

What then, one wonders at the start of the book, is the point of returning to the base camp and starting the climb all over again? Particularly since Leavitt very archly describes his ascent as a "novel" that is also about real people living in real time, pursuing questions about mathematical equations that are supposed to exist in hyper-real time. Such, however, is the

strange fascination of the Ramanujan-Hardy conundrum, their passion for prime numbers and their search to find ways of ordering them, that even the most dim-witted of readers will find the account utterly enthralling. This time round, it's a much more intimate and deliberately romantic version of the strange encounter, complete with violins playing in the background, as Hardy watches Ramanujan lift his face up to feel the snowflakes falling on his face during his first winter at Cambridge, the muffled rattle of anti-aircraft guns rip-

PRIME ORDEAL: There are set pieces about the gauche south Indian Brahmin

groan loud and long in the dark about it. Hardy is a sensualist manqué. Even the way he strokes his cat Hermione has something hard and dry about it. It allows one to think that this is the same type of caress he offers to Ramanujan. He is possessive, but will not allow himself to be possessed.

Leavitt's research into, and account of, Hardy's milieu is what makes the novel a brilliant re-creation of a society at war with itself. There are the set pieces about Ramanujan—for instance, the failed dinner that he tries to prepare for his Indian friends (in this version Hardy is also included). These are all true stories, though Leavitt does

not seem to be able to exploit the tension that may have existed between the gauche south Indian Brahmin and his more anglicised Bengali friends. He is no different from Saboo, the jungle boy stereotype; at one point, when an Emma Thompson-type of English woman tries to grab him for a kiss, his lips are dry and taste of tea.

One must also quibble about the flavour of the mathematics, like that of the *rasam* Ramanujan is shown cooking frequently without the tamarind. While Kanigel's account gave prime space to prime numbers, in Leavitt's novel the thread that runs through the tightly wrapped layers is the Riemann Hypothesis. This Sphinx-like riddle many mathematicians have attempted to solve and

which has formed the ball of thread in numerous mystery stories involving sudden insights into the zero sum theory flickers through the narrative with a persistence that is as desperate as it is futile. There is no solution. Much of Ramanujan's brilliance is also left unexplained, or at least, is inaccessible to the lay reader.

Read Leavitt by all means. If you want to get to the summit, however, the Kanigel route is far more exhilarating. ■



SAURABH SINGH

ping England and destroying, perhaps forever, its post-Victorian certitudes.

It's Ramanujan meets *Chariots of Fire*. There are the usual exquisite exposes of English upper class manners as depicted in the opening scenes of an evening spent with the "Apostles", the most exclusive of secret societies at Cambridge, and lower class ones, as Hardy and friends pursue their lusts for the "love that dare not speak its name", though everyone apparently is more than willing to